Trick or Treat
your way.

Halloween, Your Child's Way

Some children love Halloween. Some are curious about parts of it. Some enjoy joining in for a little while, while others prefer to experience it in a completely different way.

Costumes, darkness, unfamiliar faces, unexpected visitors, decorations, smells, sounds and changes to the usual evening routine can all feel very different from one child to another.

There is no single way your child needs to experience Halloween.

They might choose to:

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- join in for one small part
- watch from a distance
- stay in familiar clothes
- avoid decorations they dislike
- stay at home
- choose a completely different activity
- decide they do not want to take part at all

The aim is not to help your child "do more" each year. It is to understand what feels comfortable, interesting or manageable for them.

There are lots of ways to experience Halloween. The right one is the one that works for your child.

What kind of Halloween do I want?

Halloween can look different for different people.
I can choose what feels good for me.
I can change my mind later.

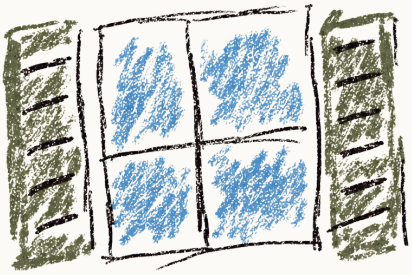
Stay at home

Dress up

Wear something small

Go trick or treating

Give out treats



Just watch

Change my mind

Build My Halloween
Cut. Choose. Order. Change.

Cut out the cards. Choose the ones that fit your Halloween. Put them in order together.

Tip for grown-ups:

Start with the parts you know are likely to happen, then add one or two “maybe” cards.

Communication Can Look Different

Speech is only one way a child can communicate.

Some children speak. Some use little or no speech. Some use AAC, signs, gestures, pictures, objects, movement or facial expressions. Some children may use speech comfortably in one situation but find it much harder when they are tired, excited, anxious or overwhelmed.

Throughout this pack, your child does not need to answer questions out loud.

They might communicate by:

- pointing
- choosing between pictures
- moving or placing a card
- handing you an object
- using AAC
- signing or gesturing
- moving towards or away from something
- asking a familiar adult to communicate for them
- showing through their behaviour that something feels comfortable or uncomfortable

Sometimes a child may not be able to tell you exactly why something feels wrong.

That does not make the discomfort less real, and you do not always need to understand the reason before making an adjustment.

Look for communication, not just words.

The activities in this pack are designed to give your child more ways to show you what works for them, not to test how well they can explain it.

“Sometimes Halloween changes”

Halloween can be unpredictable.

A door might not open, a dog might bark, another child might arrive at the same time, or a decoration might suddenly move or make a noise.

For some children, these **small surprises can feel much bigger** when they are already managing costumes, darkness, unfamiliar sounds and lots of social interaction.

You can **practise** by choosing one situation card and asking:

“What could we do if this happened?”

Then let your child choose the response that feels right to them..

We decide to go home earlier.

We skip a house.

Someone is wearing
a scary costume.

A decoration
suddenly makes a noise.

Nobody answers
the door.

There are other
children waiting.

A dog barks.

Costume Comfort Check

A costume can look great and still feel uncomfortable.

Before Halloween, explore the costume together, without any pressure to put it all on at once.

Try it. Feel it. Place it.

Use the body picture to help your child show how different parts of their costume feel.

Cut out the **I LIKE THIS FEELING**, **I'M NOT SURE** and **I DON'T WANT THIS** markers. Your child can place them on the parts of the body where they notice each feeling.

You can use a little reusable adhesive putty, such as Blu Tack, so the markers can be moved and changed as you explore.

Make it a real sensory activity

If you can, bring in the actual materials your child might wear.

- Try small pieces of:
- costume fabric
- their usual comfortable clothing
- a cape or cloak
- a mask
- a hat or headpiece
- face paint on a small area of skin
- gloves
- tights or socks
- different fastenings, seams or labels

Let your child touch, hold, rub or briefly try each one before deciding where their marker belongs.

- You might explore questions such as:

- **How does it feel on your hands?**
- **Would it feel different on your face or neck?**
- **Is it soft, scratchy, tight, sticky, heavy or hot?**
- **Does it make a sound when you move?**
- **Would you like to wear it for a little while, or not at all?**

There is no need to test everything, and your child does not need to touch or wear something they do not want to.

Look at the whole costume together

Something that feels fine for a few seconds may feel different after ten minutes. Several small sensations can also add up, a tight collar, warm fabric, a noisy cape and face paint might each be manageable on their own but feel like too much together.

Once you have explored the pieces, decide together:

What can stay?
What could we change?
What could we remove?
What could we swap for something more comfortable?

You can even create a backup costume using ordinary comfortable clothes and just one Halloween item.

"texture testing zones"

"texture testing zones"

Costume Detective

Same person. Different look.

Halloween costumes can make people look very different. A familiar face might be covered by a mask, make-up, a wig, a hat or a costume.

For some children, it can be helpful to see clearly that **the person underneath has not changed.**

This activity lets your child explore that idea slowly, using pictures and someone they already know.

Start with the picture sequence

Look at the four pictures together:

1. **This is the person as they usually look.**
2. **Now they add one costume item.**
3. **Now they are wearing the full costume.**
4. **The costume comes off, and it is the same person again.**

You can point to each picture and use simple phrases such as:

“Same person.”
“Different clothes.”
“The mask changes how they look.”
“Underneath, it is still them.”

There is no need to ask your child lots of questions. You can simply look at the pictures together and repeat the idea in whatever way is easiest for them to understand.

Make it personal

The most useful part of this activity is using someone your child already knows.

Choose a parent, sibling, relative or another familiar person.

Add two photographs:

WITHOUT COSTUME
A clear photo of the person as your child usually sees them.

WITH COSTUME
A photo of the same person wearing their Halloween costume.

Look at both pictures together and notice what has changed, and what has stayed the same.

You might say:
"This is Dad."
"Dad is wearing a mask."
"His face looks different, but it is still Dad."

If possible, use the real costume too. Let your child watch the person put it on one piece at a time:

normal clothes → hat → make-up → mask → full costume

Then take everything off again.
Seeing the transformation happen in front of them can make the idea much clearer than only seeing the finished costume.

Play detective

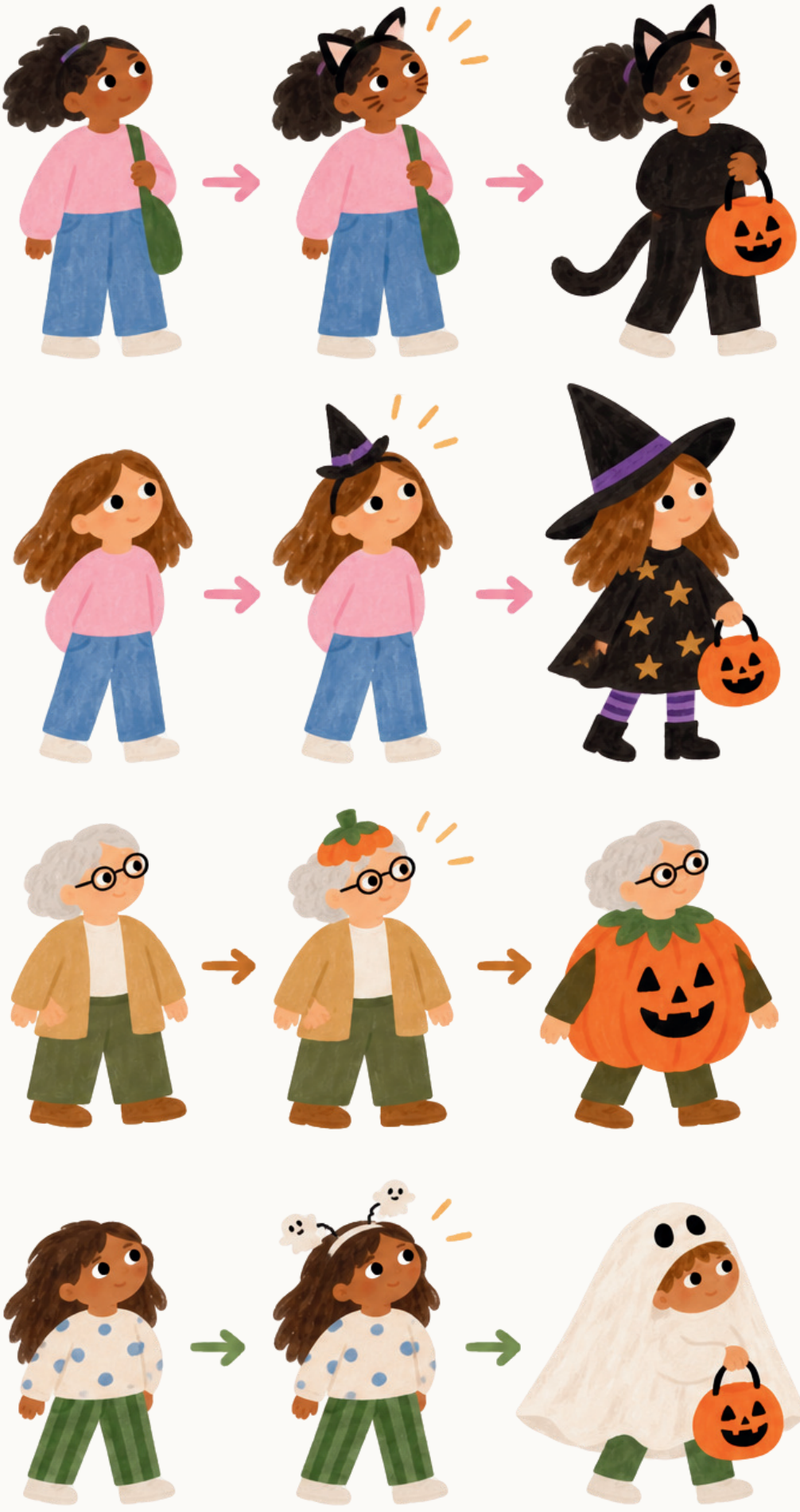
You can turn it into a simple game.
Ask: **"What changed?"**

Your child can point, match or choose:
clothes. hair. face hat mask.make-up. voice

Then ask: **"What stayed the same?"**

The answer is always: **The person**

Your child does not need to answer verbally. They can point, use AAC, choose a picture or simply watch.



Make it personal

Halloween Doesn't End at the Front Door

Getting home does not always mean your child's body and brain have finished processing the experience.

An enjoyable evening can still be a demanding one. After lots of sensory input, movement, uncertainty and interaction, some children need time with very few demands before they feel settled again.

Your child might want silence, movement, their favourite activity, familiar food, the same programme they usually watch, time alone or simply to do very little.

They may also seem more tired, irritable or sensitive than you expected, even if they appeared to enjoy the evening.

This is not always the best moment to analyse what happened.

Questions such as:
"Did you have fun?"
"What was your favourite part?"
"Why did you get upset at that house?"

can wait.

Give recovery first. Reflection can come later, if it is useful to your child at all.

Notice, don't interrogate

- Later, you might quietly think about:
- What seemed to give them energy?
- What seemed to use the most energy?
- Was there a point when things changed?
- What did they choose when they needed to regulate?
- What would you keep or change next time?

You are not looking for a perfect Halloween.

You are learning a little more about what makes experiences accessible for your child.